

LIFE AFTER ALICE

Episode 1: "Contingency"

Written by

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Cold open. Approx. five minutes.
2026

FADE IN:

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - WAITING ROOM - MORNING

A plastic fern. A water cooler that gurgles every forty seconds. A laminated sign: PLEASE SWITCH PHONES TO SILENT.

ALICE, 40s, headscarf, cardigan buttoned one hole out, peels a satsuma in a single unbroken strip. She lays the peel on her knee like a trophy.

DANIEL, 40s, beside her. A clipboard. His pen hovers over "Reason for attending" and stays there.

ALICE
Put logistics.

DANIEL
I'm not putting logistics.

She takes the clipboard off him, writes one word in capitals, hands it back with a segment of satsuma.

He eats the satsuma. Reads the form: "HIM."

A door opens. RUTH, 60s, reading glasses on a chain, leans out.

RUTH
Alice? Daniel?

Alice is up first. She pockets the peel.

ALICE
Present.

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - RUTH'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Two armchairs. A sofa. A box of tissues dead centre on a low table. Alice takes an armchair. Daniel takes the far end of the sofa. The clock is loud.

Alice pulls a black notebook from her bag. Coloured tabs bristle from every edge. On the cover, in silver marker: LIFE AFTER ALICE.

ALICE
I've done an agenda. Item one, the boiler. The service plan renews in March and he will let it lapse, he lets everything--

DANIEL
Al. She's not a solicitor.

ALICE
I know she's not a solicitor, Dan.
I'm not an idiot. I'm dying.

Nobody moves. Daniel looks at the tissues.

RUTH
Daniel. What's on yours?
He thinks about it. Properly.

DANIEL
Item one. Not doing this.

ALICE
Item one's taken.

His eyes go to the notebook on her knee. The silver letters.

FLASH TO:

INT. THEIR KITCHEN - NIGHT (THREE WEEKS EARLIER)

Two a.m. Rain on the glass. One lamp on.

Alice at the table in a dressing gown, writing in the notebook. A row of highlighters in front of her, lids off.

Daniel in the doorway, squinting against the light.

He comes to the table. Reads the cover. Reads it again.

DANIEL
It's two in the morning. You've
given it a title.

ALICE
Everything needs a title.

He picks up a highlighter. Puts the lid on. Picks up the next one. Lid on. All of them, one by one, while she watches him do it.

ALICE (CONT'D)
I was using those.

DANIEL
Come to bed.

He goes. She waits until she hears the stairs.

Then she takes the lids off again. One by one.

BACK TO:

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - RUTH'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Ruth holds out a hand for the notebook. Alice hesitates, then gives it up. Ruth turns pages: a diagram of the fuse box. THINGS HE WILL GET WRONG. A page with only COLANDER - BOTTOM LEFT, underlined three times.

RUTH
This is very thorough.

ALICE
I ran projects for eleven years.
Everything came in on time.

DANIEL
This one's coming in early.

It lands. Ugly. He hears it land. Doesn't take it back.

ALICE
Page fourteen.

RUTH
(reading)
"Daniel to join a cycling club by
June."

DANIEL
It's got a date on it.

ALICE
You need dates or you don't do
things.

DANIEL
I'll do what I want. After.

ALICE
After what?

Nothing.

ALICE (CONT'D)
Go on. After what, Dan?

He gets up. Goes to the window. Stands with his back to the room.

FLASH TO:

INT. HOSPITAL CORRIDOR - DAY (EIGHT MONTHS EARLIER)

Strip lights. A vending machine hums.

Alice on a plastic chair, a leaflet folded very small in her fist. Daniel pacing, thumb going on his phone.

DANIEL

There's a place in Heidelberg.
They've got a trial on, if we go
private--

ALICE

Can you get me some crisps.

He stops. Stares at her. She holds out a pound coin.

He feeds the machine. The spiral turns. The packet tips forward. Hangs there.

He hits the glass. Flat palm. Then his fist. Again. Again--

The packet drops. He stays there, forehead on the glass, knuckles split.

Behind him, Alice starts laughing. Can't stop. Then he's laughing too, the awful kind. He slides down the wall and puts his head in her lap.

She opens the crisps over his head. Eats one.

ALICE

Prawn cocktail. Course it is.

BACK TO:

INT. COUNSELLING PRACTICE - RUTH'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Daniel at the window. He rubs his thumb across two of his knuckles. A faded white scar.

RUTH

It's a Tuesday. A year from now.
Seven o'clock. Where are you,
Daniel?

DANIEL

Don't know.

RUTH

Guess.

DANIEL
Kitchen.

RUTH
Doing what?

DANIEL
Standing in it.

RUTH
Is the light on?

He doesn't answer. Alice closes the notebook.

ALICE
The colander's bottom left. Behind
the slow cooker.
Eleven years you've drained pasta
with a saucepan lid. It goes
everywhere, it goes all over the--

Her voice goes. Just goes, mid-word. She presses the
notebook against her mouth.

Daniel turns. Crosses the room. Not fast. Kneels on the
carpet in front of her chair and puts his arms round her
waist, his head against her. The same shape as the corridor.

Her hand finds the back of his neck. Holds on. Ruth slides
the tissues an inch closer. Nobody takes one.

DANIEL
(into her cardigan)
I'll get a colander.

ALICE
You've got a colander.

DANIEL
Backup.

She laughs into his hair. Wet. Ugly.

RUTH
Before next week. One thing each,
in the back of that book. Daniel,
something you want. For after.
Alice, something for now.

Alice opens the notebook at the back and holds the pen out
to him. He looks at it a long time. Takes it. Writes: "Learn
the lasagne."

Underneath, in capitals, she writes: "FRIDAY. KITCHEN. LAMP ON. DANCE." Shows him. He nods. Doesn't trust himself with anything else.

Alice stands, brisk again, coat half on.

ALICE
Same time next week?

RUTH
Same time.

Alice goes. Daniel follows. Stops in the doorway.

DANIEL
And when it's--

He can't.

RUTH
Same time. Same chair.

He goes.

Ruth alone. On the cushion of Alice's chair, fallen from her pocket: a long curl of satsuma peel, still unbroken. Ruth picks it up. Doesn't throw it away.

CUT TO BLACK.

LIFE AFTER ALICE